

Question 43 · Unit 3 · 8 Marks

Explain on-the-job and off-the-job training methods with suitable examples.

Introduction

A training method is the way learning is organised so that objectives are achieved. The two big families are on-the-job training (OJT) and off-the-job training. On-the-job means learning while doing real work, usually at the workplace. Off-the-job means learning away from the daily workstation so that attention is on learning, not on today's output.

A good 8-mark answer defines both, gives several examples, advantages, limitations, and says how an HRD professional should choose. 21st-century HRD also uses e-learning, which can support both families; you may mention it briefly, but the question asks for on-the-job and off-the-job.

Detailed points

- 1. On-the-job training — meaning.** The employee learns in the actual work setting, guided by a supervisor or experienced worker, using real tools and real (or carefully chosen) tasks. Learning and producing happen together. It is the oldest method and still the most common for practical skills.
- 2. OJT examples.** Coaching and mentoring by the boss; job rotation (moving through related jobs); apprenticeship; internship; understudy or shadowing a senior; instruction while working (JIT — job instruction training); action-learning projects on a live problem. Example: a new railway technician tightens joints under a senior's eye, then independently.
- 3. OJT advantages and limitations.** Advantages: high relevance, extra cost often low, transfer is easier because the workplace is the classroom, real customers and machines. Limitations: the coach may be unskilled, impatient, or busy with production; the learner may pick up bad habits; dangerous work can injure; quality of OJT varies wildly between bosses. HRD must train the coaches, not assume every senior is a teacher.
- 4. Off-the-job training — meaning.** Learning away from the regular job — in a classroom, workshop, vestibule (a simulated workplace near the factory), external institute, or conference — so that the person is not answering production calls every five minutes.
- 5. Off-the-job examples.** Lecture and discussion; case study; role play; management games; sensitivity or laboratory training; vestibule training on dummy machines; simulation; outdoor/experiential programmes; formal courses and seminars. Example: nurses practise emergency drills on mannequins before a real casualty.
- 6. Off-the-job advantages and limitations.** Advantages: focused attention, expert faculty, safer practice, deeper concepts, mixing with people from other departments (which helps collaboration). Limitations: cost, time away from work, the classroom may not look like the job (transfer problem), and possible irrelevance if TNA was weak.
- 7. How to choose — comparison.** OJT is usually better for routine practical skills already present in the workplace. Off-the-job is better when the task is new or dangerous, when concepts must be built, or when the workplace itself teaches the wrong method. Never say one family is always superior.
- 8. HRD view — blend.** Most serious development programmes combine both: concept and safe practice off-the-job, then OJT coaching, then review. Method is the servant of TNA objectives, not a fashion.

Conclusion. Define OJT and off-the-job, give at least three examples each, one advantage and one limit each, and conclude that HRD blends methods according to the learning need, safety and transfer. Examples make this answer score.